



In the midst of a sporting blitz

Backed by world-class infrastructure, Qatar is **positioning** itself as a preferred host for major international sporting events.

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The last couple of months of 2025 were particularly eventful for Qatar. The country hosted three major FIFA tournaments in quick succession — the Under-17 World Cup, Arab Cup and Intercontinental Cup. Nearly 180 matches were played by approximately 100 clubs and national teams across various stadiums, with the bulk of the U-17 World Cup staged within the state-of-the-art Aspire Academy complex. Yet even after Morocco pipped Jordan in the Arab Cup final on December 18, Qatar's stint as a sporting host was far from over.

The focus soon shifted to chess, as Doha welcomed the world's best players for the FIDE World Rapid and Blitz Championships, held at the Sports and Events Complex on the Qatar University campus. It marked the second time the Qatari capital hosted the tournament, having first done so in 2016.

"We are very pleased to be here in Doha, just one day before the opening of the World Rapid and Blitz Championships," FIDE

president Arkady Dvorkovich said.

"It's a beautiful place with a rich and successful chess history and players really love this place, which is why they have all come here to show their best qualities."

Overall, the year gone by has been an eventful one for Qatar, highlighting its diverse hosting capabilities. It also signals the country's emergence as a global hub for major sporting events beyond football. Earlier in December last year, Doha hosted the ISSF World Cup Finals, a year ahead of hosting the 2026 World Shooting Championships for the first time. "Qatar is increasingly becoming a global centre for major sporting